speaking in high-flown English at hall meetings with little effort to reach out to the masses.

While Congress sessions were becoming a regular annual event, global events did not leave the region untouched. Anti-colonial and nationalist ideas found a fertile ground in Indian minds. Italy's defeat in Abyssinia (1896) and the Japanese victory against Russia (1905) showed that Europeans were not invincible, shaping the sense that educated classes had of India's place in the world.

The Partition of Bengal created ripples in the placid waters of Madras. There were widespread, even if sporadic, protest meetings not only in Madras City but in many towns such as Coimbatore, Tirunelveli, Thanjavur, Kanchipuram, Kumbakonam, Salem and Mannargudi. Swadeshi activity gained further momentum in the following years. An exclusive urban phenomenon, with the involvement of the nascent petty-bourgeoisie—journalists, teachers, lawyers, traders and students—its spread was patchy but with some significant spikes. A notable aspect of the movement was the emergence of a cluster of extraordinarily gifted younger patriots who outshone the earlier generation, though a few veterans like G. Subramania Iyer and C. Vijayaraghavachari continued to contribute in significant ways. VOC, Subramania Siva, Ethiraj Surendranath Arya, V. Chakkarai Chettiar and S. Krishnaswami Sarma went on to make noteworthy contributions to the social and political life of the region in the subsequent decades. The flowering of the poet Subramania Bharati as the pre-eminent cultural figure of modern Tamilnadu redounds to the lasting credit of the movement.

New journals were launched, often with 'Swadeshi' prefixed to the names. Circulation of nationalist journals shot up.[5] Political journalism gained a new edge, and vernacular editorials and reporting became combative. A major change in the nature of political activity was the advent of public meetings. Rather than a homogenous group of educated, urban people being addressed in Victorian English in closed halls, Swadeshi meetings mobilized a diverse audience in an open, non-hierarchical space. In Madras City, the beach and the Moore Market emerged as locations of public gatherings where often thousands gathered to listen to the new mode